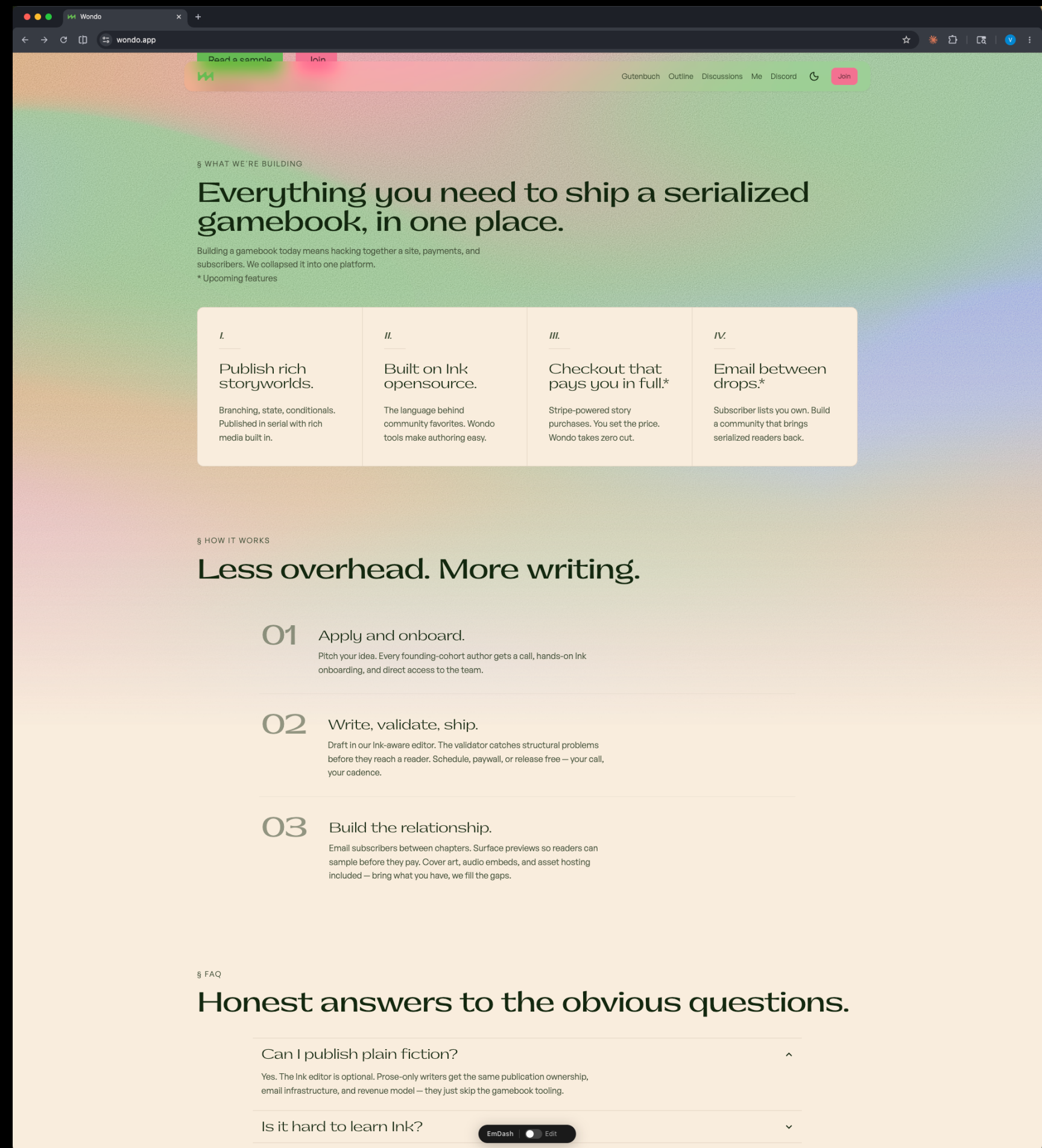


Wondo

Building a creator-economy platform for interactive fiction as a solo founder-designer-developer

Designer and Developer - 2026

This case study is about *agentic methods*: how research, prototyping, and engineering run as three parallel threads when one person owns all three, and what the resulting product reveals about a way of working.



itch.io

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Game Jams

Search for games, jams, tags or creators

Log in

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FILTER RESULTS

(Clear)

Tags

ink

Suggest description for this tag

Platform

Play in browser

Windows

macOS

Linux

Android

iOS

Price

Free

On Sale

Paid

\$5 or less

\$15 or less

When

Last Day

Last 7 days

Last 30 days

Genre

Input methods

Average session length

Multiplayer features

Accessibility features

Type

Misc

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Hells Vignette

LAST POINT

2024_DL

BnF_DL Multimedia

Games

Jala Prendes

Made with binksl

Ju / smwhr

https://itch.io/games

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Text based

Interactive Fiction

Short

Queer

Story Rich

Narrative

LGBT

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Visual Novel

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A DAY OF MAINTENANCE

A Queer Truck-Sim VN Puzzle game

A Day of Maintenance

A time-looping worker-placeme...

BigHandInSky

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

A FORGETFUL LOOP

A short kinetic novel — on brigh...

A Forgetful Loop

A time-looping worker-placeme...

BigHandInSky

Puzzle

Play in browser

cover me in leaves

10mg: Cover Me In Leaves

A short kinetic novel — on brigh...

Elliot Herriman

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

I accidentally insulted a witch and now all of my clothes are sentient and they hate me!

An Exact Map of the Empire

What the Emperor demands is l...

Avery Hiebert

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

The Restricted Archive

Steal the Necronomicon from ...

Avery Hiebert

Adventure

Play in browser

SERUM RUN

Serum Run

A dogsled Oregon Trail-like orig...

Avery Hiebert

Adventure

Play in browser

That Which Faith Demands

a scientist juggles monster-buil...

Jenna Yow

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

Build-A-Monster

zorkie

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

PAPER TANKS (indie game, ink, doodle, unity, 2d, actio...

The drawings in the notebook L...

CHILL & PLAY

Action

Play in browser

PAPER FOLK

Paper folk

ink on paper platformer

dorian beaugendre

Platformer

Play in browser

The Archipelago

a narrative game about tea and ...

Kaelan DM

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

an easy lay.

an easy lay

Romance is complicated. Roma...

SpideFlorist

Play in browser

8arms

8arms

a correspondence

DOMINO CLUB

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

Leechcraft

Leechcraft

Drenched in blood

ainsley

Interactive Fiction

Play in browser

inkle

about books blog press

ink

A narrative scripting language for games.

80-days.ink

No issues

1 I looked at Monsieur Fogg

2 ... and I could contain myself no longer.

3 'What is the purpose of our journey, Monsieur?'

4 'A wager,' he replied.

5 'A wager!' I returned.

6 He nodded.

7 'But surely that is foolishness!'

8 'A most serious matter then!'

9 He nodded again.

10 'But can we win?'

11 'That is what we will endeavour to find out,' he answered.

12 'A modest wager, I trust?'

13 'Twenty thousand pounds,' he replied, quite flatly.

14 I asked nothing further of him then[,] and after a final, polite cough, he offered nothing more to me.

15 'Ah! :):' I replied, uncertain what I thought.

16 After that, and

17 ... but I said nothing[] and

18 we passed the day in silence.

19 -> END

I looked at Monsieur Fogg

... and I could contain myself no longer.

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'A most serious matter then!'

Every one of our games (and many others besides) has had one piece of technology that has remained constant, a bedrock that has enabled us to write literally millions of words of highly branching narrative: our scripting language, ink.

EPIC MegaGrants Recipient

Getting Started

If you're new to ink, why not download Inky, our ink editor that allows you to play and test your stories.

The basics tutorial below has been written with a non-technical audience in mind, covering just the basics for people who want to write stories that they can put on the web.

And to see everything that ink has to offer, read the writer's manual, or buy the official user's guide.

BASICS TUTORIAL

WRITER'S MANUAL

THE OFFICIAL GUIDE

Inky

Write, test and export your ink stories all in one app.

DOWNLOAD:

MAC

WINDOWS

LINUX

More versions and release notes

ink - the language

★ Markup, not programming: Text comes first, code and logic are inserted within.

★ Simple, elegant syntax: Why not get a taste in the *writing tutorial*?

★ Proven: literally millions of words of content have been written for our *own games*.

★ Easy to learn, but with powerful constructs for more advanced scripting.

★ Conceived as middleware: a narrative engine designed to slot into a game engine.

Inky - the editor

★ Play as you write: The play pane automatically refreshes and reloads the choices you made.

★ Error highlighting, as-you-type.

★ Jump to definition: alt-click on a divert (they're like hyperlinks in ink) to jump to the target.

★ Export to JSON, ink's intermediate compiled format.

★ Export to web: Generates a page *like this one*, ready to be customised.

Interactive fiction sits in a structural gap where solutions force authors into game development instead of game design

Wondo is an indie publishing platform and marketplace for interactive fiction with rich media, game state, and branching narrative.

The market sits between two larger worlds: serial-fiction readers on Wattpad, Royal Road, Manta and indie game stores like itch.io and Steam. Neither serves IF natively.

Today's authors face a choice: build their own game engine, or distribute through stores that treat IF as a niche game category. Either way, efforts goes into infrastructure and distribution instead of game narrative design.

IF consists of a niche audience but there are adjacent serialized fiction reading communities

The supply-side observation comes from research:

- **r/interactivefiction** small, devoted, IF-native
- **r/gamebooks** heritage CYOA audience, distinct from IF-native
- **r/wattpad and adjacent serial-fiction communities** large, hungry for accessible interactive content but not served
- **itch.io** published ratio of 7 developers to 1 player across indie games

Wondo's strategy: lower development and distribution tax authors pay and pitch IF to adjacent reader communities by being mobile first.

Solo founder, three roles, drawing on prior community-scaling experience

My role

Founder, designer, and developer solo.

Research, design, prototyping, spec-writing, and engineering all owned end-to-end.

Prior experience scaling a community through a web magazine. The audience-engagement work on Wondo is drawing on a playbook I've used before, applied to a different category.

Out of scope (deliberately)

Advanced game mechanics audio narration, animation, dice systems are on the roadmap but not in beta.

Production complexity in those areas would raise the bar for authors at the exact moment Wondo is trying to lower it. Mobile reading benefits from text-first until the platform finds its footing.

Five intentional constraints that for rapid engineering

Emdash CMS as an AI harness skip building data model, editing, roles, auth. Acts as a guardrail: if a feature can be descoped to fit Emdash, it usually is.

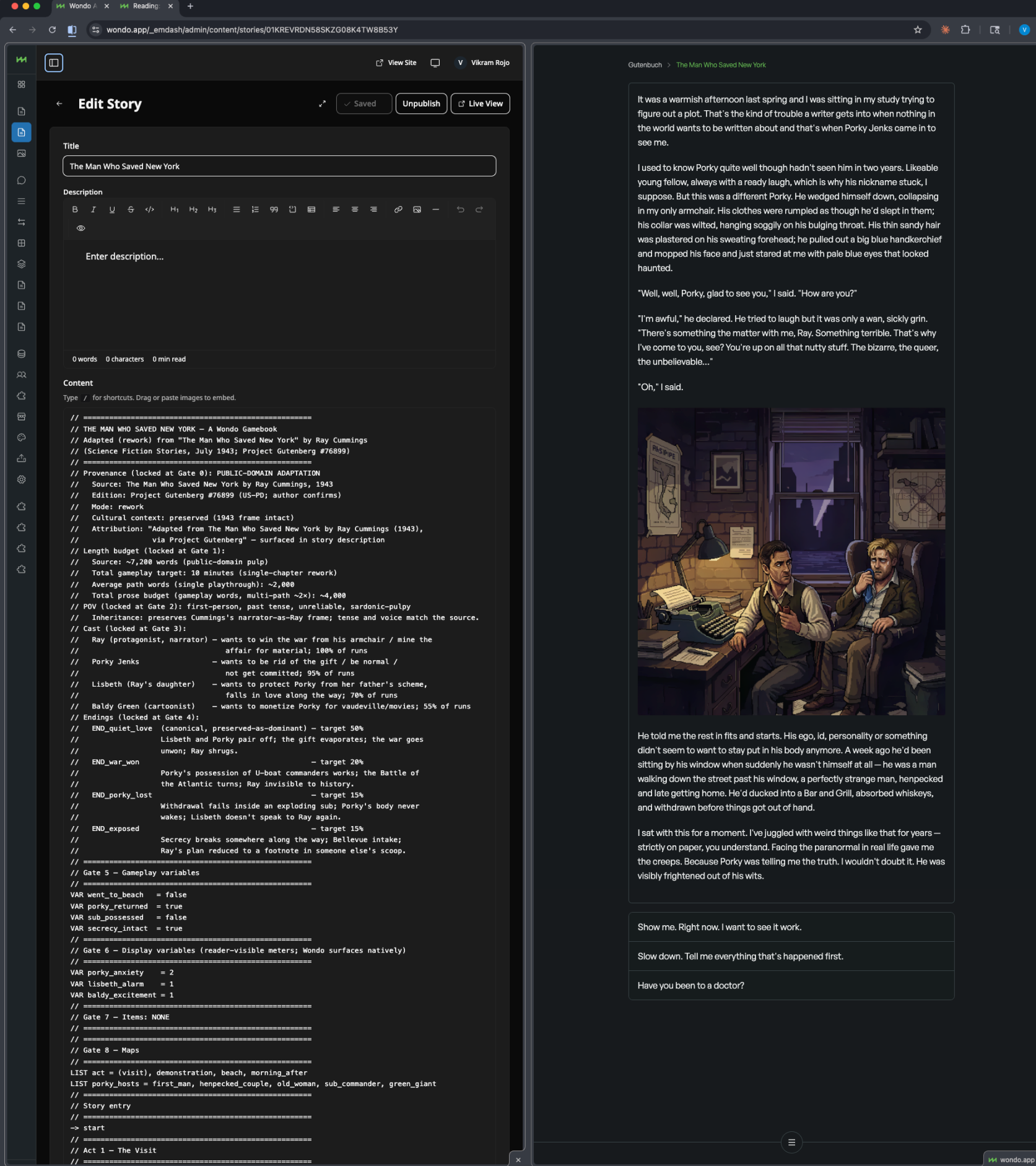
Ink as the runtime Inkle's open-source IF language. Authors arriving from other tools transfer immediately; existing community come for free.

AstroJS on Cloudflare edge popular stack for light content sites. Adding an API layer makes it a SaaS/site hybrid.

Tailwind, minimal brand design system layer handled. The brand is deliberately quiet so it doesn't compete with the content.

Stripe Connect for author-owned commerce authors own their stores and their relationship with readers. Wondo isn't a marketplace that sits in the middle.

Wondo Case Study



Spec-driven development as design artifact, engineering contract, and discipline

Prototyping on Wondo doesn't look like Figma comps that get translated to engineering:

Write a spec that captures research and design intent before any code

Phased build so engineering proceeds with design gates

The spec is the design artifact *and* the engineering contract.

Spec Driven Development collapses design and engineering into one document that captures background, sketches and tracks tasks and changes.

Wondo Case Study

via AuthorBilling status check, not middleware

as design artifact,

What Changes

Stripe Accounts v2 migration: Plan 4 v1 Express account creation (if won't stripe with the v2 API). New accounts: get_merchant_v2, customer_v2, recipient_v2, enabling stripe_balance as a billable payment method. Existing v1 accounts are manageable via the v2 API (though re-onboarding).

- **Connect onboarding via the same modal:** At step 2, the author either submits a real form POST to `/api/me/stripe/connect` (which 302s the browser to Stripe's hosted onboarding) or clicks "Skip for now". Skipping closes the modal and surfaces a persistent "Connect Stripe to start your free trial" banner on `/me/settings` (not `/me`).

Figma Comps

- Plan gating: checkout/intent.ts rejects PaymentIntent creation if the author's AuthorBilling status is not `trialing` or `active`. All outline cap is unchanged for this change (3/week for all authors).

New Capabilities

• `auto_billing`: `author_platiers` (Free / 50% discount-free trial) to connect activation, plan, and recurring billing to Stripe Billing Connect (`stripe_balance`: `primary`, CC fallback), and the billing lifecycle (`trial` → `active` → `past_due` → `suspended` → `free`).

Three Goals

- Annual billing option (dropped) \$36/yr vs \$39/yr equivalent is not a meaningful differentiator; Pro is a single price of \$19.50 every 6 months).
- Monthly billing option.
- AI outline cap differentiation between Free and Pro (deferred).
- Author disconnect / rotate-key / refresh flows on /me/settings (remain in EmDash admin).
- Admin multi-author operations view (cohort-scale billing ops deferred).
- Changing existing reader entitlements, payroll UX, or checkout flow beyond the plan-status gate.
- Quota enforcement for outline usage: Pro tier (cap unchanged).

NetChes and tracks tasks and

Everything works in beta
and the hardest
engineering problems were
where third-party
composition is fragile

What's working today, end to end:

- Authors can sign up, publish IF written in Ink, configure their own stores via Stripe Connect, and reach readers on mobile
- Readers can browse, read, tip, and subscribe
- I've dogfooded the platform by adapting public-domain Gutenberg short SF into playable IF with branching choices and pixel animations real polished titles, not promo mocks
- Current work is improving user experience and implement a go-to-market plan

Wondo Case Study

